

 EDITORIAL STYLE GUIDE

One publication. Four series. Thirty episodes, locked.

This is the canonical reference — every post is built against it. The design language does not change for at least the first 30 episodes. People follow consistency, not creativity: anyone seeing a single slide, even a cropped screenshot six months from now, should instantly think **"That's Startup Sutra."**

01 Positioning

StartupSutra is a **media brand**, not a meme page. Format: visual case studies about business decision-making, published daily at 8 PM. The company featured is always the **evidence**; the subject is the **decision**.

The Substitution Test — our editorial signature

"If I replace the company's name with another company, does the lesson still hold?"

- **Yes** → evergreen. Ship it.
- **No** → it's a history lesson. Rework it until the lesson stands alone.

Practical consequence: argument-driven structure over chronology. Open with the claim, prove it with the company, end with a question the reader must answer about **their own product**.

The mantra: the company featured is always the evidence; the subject is the decision.

We're not documenting history. We're extracting decisions.

02 The four series

Each pillar is a branded, color-coded, independently numbered series.

SERIES	ACCENT / DEEP	SUBJECT	EXAMPLE SUBJECTS
 CASE STUDY	#f59e0b / #ea580c	How a decision created success	Instagram, Airbnb, Netflix, Canva
 STARTUP FAILURE	#ef4444 / #b91c1c	How a decision destroyed value	BlackBerry, Kodak, Nokia, WeWork
 MARKETING BREAKDOWN	#3b82f6 / #1d4ed8	Why a marketing move worked	Apple, Nike, Duolingo, Red Bull
 FOUNDER FRAMEWORK	#22c55e / #15803d	A mental model founders can apply	First Principles, Flywheel, JTBD, Pareto

Series color drives

- Kicker pill + headline accent words
- Quote-card border and tint
- Active progress dot, swipe cue
- Ambient glow, highlight cards

Master brand stays amber — always

- The S logo mark
- "Sutra" in the wordmark
- The follow-card S mark
- On every series, no exceptions

Episode numbering

- Numbered **per series** — Case Study #001 ≠ Startup Failure #001.
- **Category large, number subtle.** The cover kicker shows the series name only; the number lives small in the top-right corner as #NNN · slide/07.
- The last slide teases continuity ("New episode tomorrow") without hard-coding the next series.

Published register

-  CASE STUDY #001 — Instagram (2026-07-19)
-  STARTUP FAILURE #001 — BlackBerry (2026-07-20)

03 Visual system

- **Canvas:** carousel 1080×1350 (4:5), 7 slides · reels 1080×1920 (9:16), 30fps
- **Background:** near-black navy #0b0e14 ; ambient glow in series color; faint 90px grid, masked radially
- **Text:** primary #f4f1ea · dimmed #8b93a3 · secondary #aab2c0 · footer #525a68
- **Typography:** Inter only — 900 headlines (−1.5px tracking), 800 quote cards, 700 UI, 600 body. Emoji: Noto Color Emoji.
- **Header:** S mark + wordmark left · #NNN · slide/07 right. **Footer:** dots · @StartupSutra · SWIPE →

04 Visual hierarchy rules

1. One idea per slide. The surprising element gets the biggest type.
2. Contrast carries meaning: winner bright, loser dimmed — the design argues before the copy does.
3. The screenshot slide (the lesson) is the most minimal slide of the set.
4. **Never:** stock photos, illustrations, AI imagery, gradients beyond the accent. Emojis only as functional icons.

05 Writing voice

- Short declarative sentences. One thought per line.
- Conversational verbs — "deleted", not "deprecated"; "loved", not "adopted".
- Numbers over adjectives — "1 million users in 2 months", never "huge growth".
- Second person for lessons: turn the insight toward the reader's product.
- No jargon, no hashtag stuffing, no exclamation marks. Confidence is quiet.

Hook formulas (cover slide / reel opening)

FORMULA	PATTERN	EXAMPLE
Reversal	"X didn't lose to Y. It lost to Z."	BlackBerry (SF #001)
Sacrilege	Destroy something sacred	"Imagine deleting 80% of your startup."
Near-miss	The success almost didn't happen	"The billion-dollar app almost didn't exist."
Hidden cause	"Everyone thinks Y. It was Z."	—
Question trap	A question with no easy answer	"Why did the best product lose?"

A hook is never a summary. It creates a gap the carousel closes.

06 · Carousel structure (7 slides)

1. **Hook** — series + subject pills, claim, tension line
2. **Setup** — the world before; the company's bet
3. **Shift** — what changed
4. **Evidence** — the visual argument
5. **Mistake / Insight** — the decision, named
6. **Lesson** — screenshot slide, minimal
7. **CTA** — reader question + rows + follow + tease

07 · Reel Philosophy (25–30s max)

- The reel is **not** the carousel: it creates curiosity, the carousel answers
- One idea only · no duplication of the lesson or evidence
- First 3s earn everything: cold open, no branding, logo at ~3s
- Human, not AI — a founder's observation over coffee; pauses are the delivery
- Emotion over information · end with curiosity → "full story in today's carousel"
- VO natural pace, cuts on breath boundaries; music in-app: minimal cinematic, investigative
- Voice: calm, confident, curious — no hype, no guru, no narrator

05A Human Voice Framework

The Conversation Test

"Would I actually say this in a conversation with a founder?"

If the answer is no — rewrite it. This single rule removes 90% of AI-sounding copy.

✗ Written, not spoken

"BlackBerry failed because it underestimated the app ecosystem."

✓ Revealed, not presented

"Here's the part most people miss. BlackBerry wasn't losing phones. It was losing relevance."

AI-tells to hunt down: stacked abstractions · symmetrical sentence pairs that sound written · adjectives doing the work numbers should do · explaining when you could be revealing.

The Screenshot Quote Test (hard rule) · The Unforgettable Line

Every episode must contain **one sentence people want to save** — it gets the most minimal slide and its own caption lines. **No sentence → the episode isn't finished.** And one step further: one line people **repeat months later** ("Apple changed the question. BlackBerry kept answering the old one."). Draft three candidates in Phase 2; the best earns a slide punchline. Explaining informs; **revealing gets quoted.**

07A Narration Rules (delivery)

The guide defines writing; this defines **delivery**. They are different.

- Write for speech, not reading. Maximum 8–10 words per sentence.
- Pause after every important line. One idea = one breath. Intrigue before explanation.
- Never sound like you're presenting. Sound like you're **revealing** something.
- Script format: one line per breath; ellipses mark pauses; every reel scene cut lands on a breath boundary.

11A Editorial Review — the pre-publish gate

Every episode is scored on the **finished slides** before publishing. Below target on any metric → rewrite. Not because it's "bad" — because StartupSutra doesn't publish average episodes. Scores go in the episode README.

METRIC	QUESTION IT ANSWERS	TARGET
Scroll Stop	Does slide 1 interrupt a thumb mid-scroll?	9/10
Curiosity	Does every slide make you need the next one?	9/10
Save Worthy	Is there a sentence people will screenshot?	9/10
Share Worthy	Would a founder send this to a co-founder?	8/10
Human Voice	Does it pass the Conversation Test?	10/10

08 Caption style

1. Open by restating the hook in one line (not word-for-word).
2. 4–8 short lines building the argument — each stands alone.
3. The lesson, isolated on its own lines.
4. 💬 question → ❤️ save prompt (tie to a real work moment: "for your next roadmap discussion") → 📖 2–3 sources.
5. No hashtag walls. Reel captions are shorter and never duplicate the carousel's.

09 Alt text

Every slide gets alt text: `Slide N: [text on slide, condensed]`. Cover example: *"Slide 1: BlackBerry didn't lose to Apple. It lost to the future."* Literal first — screen readers before keywords.

10 Story templates (posting day)

WHEN	ASSET	ADD
8 PM	Cover slide	"New episode" + series emoji + link sticker
+2 hours	Lesson slide	Poll: "Have you seen this mistake up close?"
Next morning	Best comment screenshot	"Tell us yours 🙋"

Stories reuse post assets only — never new designs.

11 CTA style

- One question per post, always about the reader, answerable in one line.
- Fixed rows: 🙋 Tell us below · ❤️ Save this post · 🔄 Share it with a founder.
- Follow card: "Follow @StartupSutra — daily startup case studies."
- Continuity tease on the last slide / end card; series-agnostic wording.

12 The five-phase production process

We are not making Instagram posts. We are **producing editorial episodes**. Every episode moves through five phases, in order:

Phase 1 · Research

Facts · timeline · sources · competing viewpoints. If credible accounts disagree, know both sides before choosing the angle.

Phase 2 · Editorial

Answered in writing before any design work: **What's the decision? What's the lesson? What's the screenshot quote?** Run the Substitution Test. No answers → no episode.

Phase 3 · Writing

Carousel · caption · alt text · stories. Conversation Test line by line; hunt AI-tells. Render and review every slide at full size.

Phase 4 · Performance

Reel script per Narration Rules — one line per breath, pauses marked. VO → silence-detect → cuts on breath boundaries → render → mux. Music in-app, 15–20% under VO.

Phase 5 · Review

Conversation Test on finished slides → Editorial Scorecard → final approval. Below target → back to Phase 3. Record scores in the episode README. Post at 8 PM.

13 Editorial Philosophy — the DNA

PRINCIPLE	WHAT IT MEANS
1 · Teach principles, not history	We don't publish because BlackBerry failed. We publish because founders can avoid making the same decision.
2 · Leave one question unanswered	If every question is answered inside the carousel, there's no discussion and no reason to comment. The Founder Question is real, not rhetorical.
3 · Respect the reader	Never over-dramatize. Never exaggerate. Never use clickbait the content can't justify. Curiosity is earned, not manufactured.

Benchmark:  Startup Failure #001 — BlackBerry is the first episode produced under this system. Every future episode is compared against it.

Consistency is the strategy. The guide is the brand.